Teaching Statement: Becoming Intelligent at the Age of Artificial Intelligence

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> Whenever I interact with students—as an instructor, mentor, or teaching assistant, the same question always lingers in my mind: What can my students truly learn and gain from me? I see teaching as a profound responsibility to make sure the time, financial resources, and motivation that students invest in their education are rewarded in meaningful ways. For me, that reward extends beyond technical proficiency; it includes nurturing critical thinking, ethical judgment, and the ability to continue learning independently. I believe this is particularly important as both education and society confront the influence of artificial intelligence.

I have accumulated both breadth and depth of teaching experience across traditional, hybrid, and online learning environments. At Michigan State University, I served as both an instructor and a teaching assistant for several core courses in methodology and thematic geography, working with students at both undergraduate and graduate levels. I also collaborated closely with the onGEO hybrid teaching program, where I not only taught but also helped develop and refine instructional materials to enhance students' hybrid learning experiences.

As an instructor, I have led multiple classes and lab sessions in GIS and spatial data analysis, coordinated students' project-based learning activities, and devoted significant time to one-on-one tutoring sessions. In these sessions, I assisted students in troubleshooting technical issues, refining analytical approaches, and—most importantly—understanding the logic and critical thinking process behind their minds. My supervisors have consistently evaluated my teaching as excellent for my attention to detail, while students often describe me as patient and deeply committed.

Teaching Philosophy

My teaching philosophy is grounded on two core values: inclusion and rationality. Balancing these principles allows me to create a learning environment that fosters both intellectual growth and empathy—qualities I believe are essential for students to thrive in an age of artificial intelligence.

Inclusion in my teaching has two dimensions. First, I aim to help students develop a more inclusive mindset by engaging with diverse perspectives and global issues. When teaching an online regional geography course, I noticed that many students were only interested in questions related to their home states. Thus I intentionally incorporated examples from other countries or less popular U.S. regions across both my thematic and methodology classes. These examples not only engaged a wider range of students but also encouraged them to think beyond their immediate context, develop the ability to learn about unfamiliar regions, and recognize how geospatial methods can illustrate complex real-world problems.

Second, I strive to make my teaching inclusive by addressing the diverse needs of students with varying learning abilities and styles. I pay particular attention to those who are less active during lectures, ensuring that they can follow the material and stay engaged. In-person tutoring often plays a key role in this process. In one spatial analysis course, I offered individual tutoring sessions to about 30% of the students—investing only a few hours in total—but these efforts made them feel personally supported and my effort paid off. By the end of the semester, all students in that class earned a final grade of at least 3.5.

Fostering rationality is another principle of my teaching philosophy, encouraging students to think critically, reason independently, and conduct evidence-based inquiry. I view education as more than the transfer of skills or information; it is a process that empowers students to question underlined assumptions, connect ideas, and apply knowledge to real-world challenges. Beyond mastering course content, I seek to help students develop a geographic perspective—an awareness of how spatial relationships shape social, political, and environmental systems. This is especially important in region-specific courses such as World Regional Geography, where I guide students to build coherent conceptual frameworks and explore the deeper causes of regional challenges.

Teaching Plan

I would be delighted to teach existing courses on spatial data analysis and geographic information systems (GIS). I am also well prepared to teach a range of human geography or regional geography courses, particularly those that integrate spatial thinking with contemporary social issues. In addition, I can assist with data analytic courses that emphasize programming skills in R and Python, as well as data visualization.

Looking ahead, I aim to develop new courses at the intersections of spatial analysis, mass violence, and regional studies focused on Asia. At the graduate level, I hope to design seminars on Human Geography of Modern China (or Asia), exploring the economic and social transformation of those regions through a human geographic perspective.

At the senior undergraduate level, I plan to offer a course titled Applied Geography of Violence, which would bridge theory, data, and methods. In this course, students would investigate various cases of mass violence across regions and time periods, using geographic tools to visualize, analyze, and interpret spatial patterns. The class would introduce students to multiple data sources and databases, while equipping them with advanced methods such as individual-level network analysis, spatial statistics, and GIS-based visualization.